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Red Rising

Red Rising is a 2014 dystopian science fiction novel by American author Pierce Brown. It is the first book and eponym of the series. The novel, set in the future on Mars, follows lowborn miner Darrow as he infiltrates the ranks of the elite Golds.

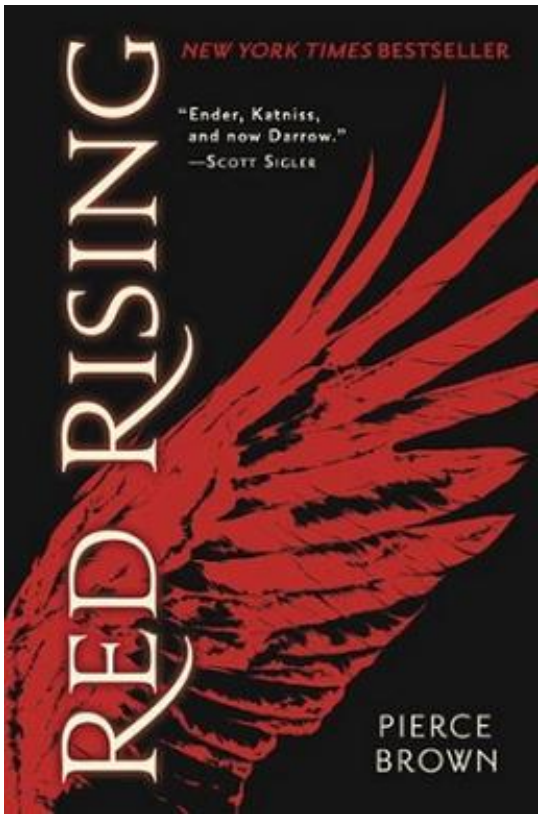
Red Rising has received generally positive reviews, and reached #20 on the *New York Times* Best Seller list.

Plot summary

Seven hundred years before the story's start, humankind colonized Luna, where the Society—a rigid social hierarchy of 14 Colors with specialized roles—was developed for efficiency and order. The Society, harshly ruled by certain families of mentally and physically superior Golds, conquered Earth and colonized moons and small planets. Reds are the Society's lowest-status laborers. Mars's underground Red mining colonies compete in rigged contests that sow discord and are lied to that Mars is not yet terraformed.

At the story's outset, 16-year-old Darrow is a rash, intelligent, dexterous, newly-wed Red helium-3 miner. Darrow and his wife Eo are publicly whipped for visiting a restricted underground forest. With Mars's ArchGovernor Nero present and the event being filmed, Eo sings a song protesting the Reds' enslavement. Nero has Eo publicly hanged. A grieving Darrow illegally buries Eo and is hanged too, but survives due to his uncle Narol drugging him.

Red Rising



First edition cover

Author	Pierce Brown
Audio read by	Tim Gerard Reynolds (Recorded Books) Various (GraphicAudio)
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	Audiobook
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Followed by	*Golden Son*

Narol then delivers Darrow to the Sons of Ares, who aim to overturn the Society's hierarchy. The Sons used footage of Eo's song and execution as propaganda. Dancer, a Red, wants Darrow to infiltrate the Society as a Gold. Darrow is physically transformed by Mickey (a Violet) via a "carving", physically trained by Harmony (a Red), and taught Gold customs by Matteo (a Pink).

Under the fabricated Gold identity of "Darrow au Andromedus", he excels in testing and is accepted into Mars's Institute. He is drafted into House Mars, one of 12 school Houses, where he befriends Cassius. The Institute begins with the Passage where students are beaten, then paired off (a high test scorer with a low test scorer) to fight to the death barehanded. Darrow kills Cassius's brother, Julian, and lies about it. A low scorer, Sevro, unexpectedly kills high-status Priam.

Next, in the Valles Marineris, each House is assigned a castle and told to conquer the other Houses. Each school House's flag can enslave other Houses' students. House Pluto, led by Nero's son Adrius ("the Jackal"), resorts to cannibalism to survive. Darrow wields a scythe; he is nicknamed "Reaper". House Mars fractures into factions: Darrow and Cassius's, Antonia's, and Titus's. Sevro operates alone. Quinn saves Darrow from Titus's faction. The bloodthirsty Titus rapes enslaved peers and captures Quinn. Cassius challenges Titus but Titus's group assaults Cassius. Darrow manipulates House Minerva, led by "Mustang" (Virginia), into defeating Titus and retreating. Sevro saves Darrow and Cassius from House Minerva. Darrow speaks to a captive Titus and realizes he is a Red that has also undergone a "carving" as an agent of the Sons of Ares. To maintain his cover, Darrow sentences Titus to death. Cassius duels and kills Titus, thinking Titus killed Julian.

Darrow outwits and enslaves House Diana and most of House Minerva but lets Virginia escape with her flag, leading the sadistic Vixus away. Adrius's subordinate, Lilath, declares a bounty on Darrow and passes Cassius a pouch that Darrow asks Sevro to steal. Cassius thwarts this and watches the pouch's video of Darrow killing Julian. Antonia, Vixus, and Cassandra use Lea to ambush Darrow. Darrow hides, and they execute Lea and flee. Cassius stabs Darrow in a duel and leaves him for dead, usurping House Mars, but Virginia rescues Darrow. As he recovers, they develop romantic feelings. Virginia falls gravely ill. Fitchner, House Mars's Proctor and Sevro's father, tells Darrow that Nero manipulated the Proctors to help Adrius. Darrow obtains medicine from Fitchner to cure Virginia.

Darrow and Virginia amass an army by freeing slaves using House Minerva's flag. When Tactus tries to rape Nyla, Darrow has both Tactus and himself whipped, earning his army's loyalty. Darrow conquers Houses Ceres and Apollo. Sevro rejoins Darrow, who incapacitates Fitchner for

his flying boots. Darrow traps Adrius, who amputates his own hand to free himself. The Proctors help Adrius counterattack and escape, Pax protects Darrow, and Adrius kills Pax. The Proctors kidnap Virginia. Enraged, Darrow slays Proctor Apollo.

With the Proctors' flying boots, Darrow's army storms Olympus, the Proctors' base, freeing Virginia and capturing the Proctors. Sevro deletes evidence that Darrow is a Red. Darrow usurps Cassius, who declares a blood feud. Learning that Virginia is Adrius's twin sister, Darrow fears her betrayal, but Virginia dutifully delivers Adrius and Darrow wins the Institute's title.

Many Golds covet Darrow. Nero proposes to help Darrow join the fleet-commanding Academy and rise to power if Darrow hides Nero's game-rigging and becomes his Lancer (*aide-de-camp*). Darrow agrees, publicly joining House Augustus.

Characters

- Darrow, a Red who is remade into a Gold named "Darrow au Andromedus" to infiltrate and destroy the Society. He is later called "The Reaper" by his classmates, for the sickle-shaped blade he carries as his weapon.
- Eo, Darrow's wife whose hanging for treason ignites his desire for revenge against the Golds.
- Nero au Augustus, the ArchGovernor of Mars who orders Eo's execution.
- Virginia au Augustus, daughter of the ArchGovernor and leader of House Minerva at the Institute. Initially not knowing her given name, Darrow calls her "Mustang".
- Adrius au Augustus, Virginia's vicious twin brother, leader of House Pluto at the Institute. His cruel and violent tactics of conquest earn him the nickname "The Jackal".
- Cassius au Bellona, Darrow's friend and ally in House Mars before he discovers that Darrow killed his brother.
- Roque, Darrow's friend and ally in House Mars, a self-styled poet.
- Sevro au Barca, Darrow's friend and ally in House Mars, a lowDraft with an antisocial attitude.
- Antonia au Severus, a ruthless Gold whom Darrow alienates almost immediately.
- Titus au Ladros, a violent and tyrannical member of House Mars.
- Pax au Telemanus, a massive warrior aligned with Virginia in House Minerva.
- Tactus au Rath, a duplicitous member of House Diana.
- Fitchner au Barca, Proctor of Mars at the Institute, Sevro's father.
- Narol, Darrow's paternal uncle, rescues Darrow after his execution and sends him to the Sons of Ares.
- Dancer, Darrow's mentor in the Sons of Ares who first reveals to him the lies of the Golds, and taught him along with Matteo.
- Harmony, Dancer's half-disfigured, female partner.
- Mickey, a Violet Carver who remakes Darrow's body and physically transforms him into a Gold.
- Matteo, a Pink who educates Darrow about the society, its history, politics, and arts.

- Octavia au Lune, the Sovereign of the Society, residing on the Moon.
- Evey, a winged-Pink who nurses and cares for Darrow during The Carving.

Development

Brown said of writing *Red Rising*, "I started with the main character [Darrow] and shaped my world around him. I was inspired by the plight of Irish immigrants in the 19th century and by the disenfranchisement of working classes."[1] Brown also explained:

> Pax's death was capricious and bothered me. I needed the Jackal to demonstrate his nature in Book 1 so I put all the names in the hat except Darrow and Mustang. When I pulled out Pax's name I stood there thinking, "I could just put it back in, no-one would ever know." I had a huge story arc planned with Darrow being with the Telemanuses against the Bellonas and that changed everything. But it was better, ultimately, that Darrow didn't have that shelter to hide behind.[2]

Reception

Red Rising was well received by both readers and critics, and hit #20 on the *New York Times* Best Seller list in February 2014.[3]

Marc Snetiker of *Entertainment Weekly* gave the book an A–, writing, "Brown writes with cinematic grandeur, cleverly fusing Roman mythology with science fiction and pacing his action scenes for a slow-burn build to a hold-your-breath final act."[4] Brian Truitt of *USA Today* gave the book 3.5 out of 4 stars, proclaiming, "*Red Rising* ascends above a crowded dystopian field."[5] Writing for *The Huffington Post*, Britt Michaelian explained, "The morals and values that are explored through the characters in *Red Rising* have the potential to inspire a generation of readers to think intelligently about the impact of their decisions on themselves, their family and friends and on their world as a whole. This book is truly a powerful lesson in leadership."[6] Niall Alexander wrote for Tor.com:

> On the surface, *Red Rising* resembles any number of other genre novels of note, but dig a little deeper … to reveal real uniqueness: in Brown's nearly seamless assemblage of several time-tested traditions, if not in a great many of his debut's myriad threads independently … Its final act … is like a heart attack: a no-holds-barred bastard of a finale in which the author gathers a spread of elements together in much the same way George R. R. Martin's does in the best and most brutal bits of his bestselling saga … For once I would have loved more in the way of worldbuilding, and Brown could have made the most

> of a longer novel by exploring a few of his fiction's most interesting figures further, but it bears remembering that *Red Rising* is only the beginning of a trilogy—which is to say there's space and time for this impressive young author to work out its biggest kinks.[7]

Kirkus Reviews described the novel as "reminiscent of *The Hunger Games* and *Game of Thrones*", calling it "a fine novel for those who like to immerse themselves in alternative worlds".[8] However, *Publishers Weekly* said of the novel, "Pierce offers a Hollywood-ready story with plenty of action and thrills but painfully little originality or plausibility."[9]

Writing for *The Writing Cooperative*, Saanvi Thapar offered a more critical assessment, rating the book 2 out of 5 stars. Though she acknowledged the premise as promising, she argued that the novel suffered from several craft-level shortcomings, including an overreliance on information-dumping, underdeveloped themes, and pacing issues. She was also critical of Darrow as a protagonist, suggesting he lacked meaningful flaws and was a "Gary Stu", which diminished his believability as a character and the meaning behind the plot. Thapar concluded that while the book had redeeming qualities, these structural weaknesses undermined the overall reading experience.[10]

Brown's *Red Rising* fans have dubbed themselves "Howlers" after characters in the novels, and the author has also noted the popularity of his novels among queer readers, saying "One of my favourite things about this tour has been seeing how popular these books have been with the lesbian, gay and transgender community. It's amazing that they have found a home in these books. One reader almost made me cry. He's transgender and identifies as male and he told me that he found a home in Sevro and feels like Sevro was the friend he never had."[2]

Prequel comic

A six-issue prequel comic book series exploring the origins of the rebel group "Sons of Ares" called *Red Rising: Sons of Ares* was published by Dynamite Entertainment in 2017.[11][12] The series was continued with six more issues published in 2020.[13]

Adaptations

Audiobooks

An audiobook of *Red Rising*, the first book in the series, was released on January 28, 2014 by Recorded Books.[14] GraphicAudio produced an audiobook of book one in two parts that include full cast, cinematic music and sound effects. Part one was released on March 22, 2023, and part

two was released on May 15.[15][16]

Other media

In February 2021, Stonemaier Games announced their *Red Rising* board game.[17] The game got a Recommendation by the International Gamers Awards 2021.[18]

In 2014, Universal Pictures secured the rights for a film adaptation, but the project was eventually scrapped. Brown began developing *Red Rising* as a television series in 2018, and insinuated that the potential series had one of the major streaming services interested in adapting the series in 2021.[19] In March 2026, Brown acknowledged that the project was no longer moving forward.[20]

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External links

- Official website (https://www.piercebrown.com/redrisingsaga)

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